

Apostrophes

APOSTROPHES SHOW POSSESSION OR OMISSION.

The apostrophe is used to create the possessive form of nouns and represents letters that have been omitted in contractions. It can also be used to create a few unusual plural nouns.

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Missing letters

An apostrophe represents missing letters in a contraction, which is when a word or words are shortened by omitting letters. There are about 100 common contractions. Only auxiliary verbs such as *be* and *have* can be used in this way.

Original form	Contracted form
it is	it's
she is	she's
who is	who's
I am	I'm
you are	you're
we are	we're
they are	they're
I have	I've
we have	we've
would have	would've

Original form	Contracted form
he had; he would	he'd
I will	I'll
you will	you'll
who will	who'll
is not	isn't
has not	hasn't
cannot	can't
could not	couldn't
will not	won't
did not	didn't

Rafael wasn't happy that the
his name with two *f*'s on

REAL WORLD

Apostrophe catastrophe

The use of apostrophes in plurals in commercial signs is widespread. This type of mistake is sometimes called a “greengrocer’s apostrophe.”



Plural forms

Occasionally, apostrophes are used to create plural forms where adding an *s* on its own would cause confusion, as when an abbreviation or a single letter is made plural. There are very few words that are pluralized in this way. Most plurals of regular nouns are formed by adding only an *s*.

with two *f*'s

Without the apostrophe, it would be unclear that the phrase is talking about the letter *f*.